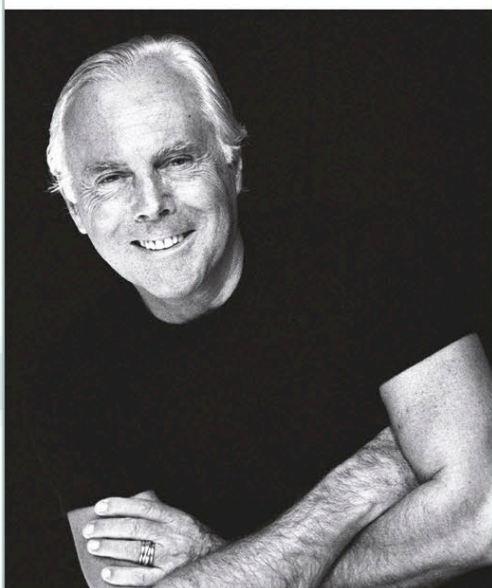


1980–2012

# A POWERFUL MESSAGE

The idea of using clothes to convey status is as old as civilization, but fashion historians point to the 1980s as the pinnacle of power dressing. As more women entered traditionally male-oriented work environments, they found it advantageous to dress as though they were in command, and sure of their sexuality. This meant jackets with heavily padded shoulders, vibrant colours, big hair-dos, bold accessories, and shoes with pointed toes and spiked heels. Throughout the decade TV series such as *Dallas* and *Dynasty* influenced women's wardrobes. These shows projected images of rich, confident women wearing jewel-toned suits with sharp shoulder lines, extravagant dresses, and larger-than-life jewellery. From the 1990s onwards designers such as Calvin Klein and Giorgio Armani developed a low-key, less "costume" style for working women. Neutral tones, expensive fabrics, and minimal lines sent a subtler message about competence and capability.

## GIORGIO ARMANI



Italian designer Giorgio Armani's luxurious, softly tailored clothes in neutral tones have been in vogue for more than 30 years. Since establishing his own label in 1976, he has become renowned for making business attire for both sexes more youthful and relaxed, yet still giving the wearer a look of authority and glamour. His preference for simplicity has significantly influenced contemporary fashion.



1990

**Crossover style** One of the most significant trends for working women was Giorgio Armani's soft, elegant tailoring. As in this 1990 outfit, he feminized men's styles, made them in luxurious fabrics in neutral colours, and fashioned a long, lean silhouette.



1980

**Colour and contour** An original outfit from the 1980s shows how contrasting colour and form can shape the body to eye-catching effect. This black, body-conscious dress with the meticulously shaped, mustard-yellow jacket creates an hourglass silhouette.



2004

**Sexy suiting** American designer Donna Karan built her brand with clothes intended to make a woman feel strong, sensual, and comfortable. Here she puts a sexy spin on the traditional, grey flannel suit, with revealing, transparent panels in the skirt.